Cambridge
O Level

Cambridge International Examinations
Cambridge Ordinary Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/21**

Paper 2 Reading **May/June 2018**

INSERT

1 hour 45 minutes

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READ THESE INSTRUCTIONS FIRST

This Insert contains the two reading passages.

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Passage 1

Elephants

1 Elephants are magnificent creatures, the largest animals on earth, and are found in sub-Saharan Africa and in parts of Asia. Throughout history, they were used as a form of transport; for example, kings and emperors were carried on highly decorated elephants, seen as fitting vehicles for such powerful individuals. Because of their strength, elephants have commonly been used as working animals, for example in the logging industry, where they can haul wagons and carry trees with minimum damage to surrounding forest areas. They were invaluable in warfare in many ancient civilisations, such as those of India and China; male elephants were used to charge against the enemy while their female counterparts carried provisions such as food and weaponry. Roman soldiers were recorded as being terrified when they first saw these huge beasts advancing towards them in battle, led by the Carthaginian general, Hannibal. Nor were elephants confined to ancient warfare, as they had a part to play in modern wars; they could cope with mountainous terrain impassable by horses and, as late as 1945, they provided brute strength to build bridges during the Second World War.

2 Elephants have always featured in the religions of several cultures, with tribes in some places believing that their chiefs would be reincarnated as elephants; elsewhere, religious processions are led by elephants adorned with lavish garments, such as in the Buddhist Festival of Esala Perahera in Kandy, Sri Lanka. The Hindu god Ganesh, revered as the god of prosperity, wisdom and intelligence, is depicted as a human with an elephant's head. Elephants are said to bring good luck, and there is much debate among some people about the importance of the position of the elephant's trunk: for example, is the elephant's trunk more auspicious if it points upwards or downwards?

3 Because the ivory of which elephants' tusks are made is really beautiful, it has for centuries been a much sought-after commodity, used in ancient times to make valuable works of art and religious objects, and in modern times to make cutlery handles and piano keys. During drought, elephants dig for water and thus produce water for other animals; this, and other behaviours, mean that elephants are described as a keystone species, that is, one which has a huge impact for good on the environment.

4 Elephants have also been used as a form of entertainment. The first elephant imported to the USA arrived in the late 1790s and was promptly put on display; by the 1880s, elephants had become popular circus performers, trained to perform tricks to dazzle appreciative audiences.

5 But these are perilous days for elephants. Many are losing their habitats because of the clearing of land for development projects such as housing, resulting in the loss of many elephants, and their babies being abandoned. Sometimes they are killed by farmers who do not want to lose their agricultural or grazing ground to national parks. Because ivory continues to be prized in art and manufacturing, it is still in great demand in some countries and, although some ivory trade is legal, much of it is the result of large-scale elephant poaching. Indeed, poaching of elephants for ivory is now seriously on the increase.

6 Because of concern about the plight of elephants nowadays, they have been classified as a threatened and, in some parts of the world, an endangered species. As the ivory trade is often perceived as being cruel and barbaric, some countries have banned it. In June 2015, more than a ton of confiscated ivory was crushed in New York's Times Square by conservationists to send a message that illegal ivory trade should not be tolerated. Keeping elephants in captivity is obviously cruel, and therefore many zoos and circuses refuse to display them. For example, the only elephant now seen in Edinburgh Zoo is a fibreglass one with a sign explaining that the conditions for keeping elephants cannot be met there; other zoos are publicly criticised for their treatment of elephants by groups such as In Defense of Animals. Other organisations, for example the World Wild Fund for Nature, raise funds to equip anti-poaching patrols and ensure conservation laws are enforced. Such is the success of these awareness-raising tactics that in many countries elephant refuges and orphanages have been established, staffed often by volunteer labour.

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Passage 2

Emma

1 Emma unlocked and pushed open the back door, staggering under the heavy bags of groceries she had just bought. She placed the bags on the kitchen counter and almost instinctively switched on the kettle to make herself a cup of tea. Her parents had gone on holiday, leaving her, as the elder, in charge of her brother. Their trust placed a huge responsibility on Emma, felt particularly because it was the first time they had left their children alone in the house together. Groping in a kitchen cupboard, she was irritated to find that the teabags had been shifted, no doubt by James, her brother. He had also left the cutlery drawer open slightly. Even worse, he had left muddy footprints all over the floor. Feeling justifiably aggrieved, Emma resolved to tell James off when he came home.

2 As Emma drank her tea, a cloud crossed her mind and gradually became a storm of doubt. Hadn't James, in accordance with their parents' instructions, left for high school before her to ensure that he was never at home alone? He had a key, but why would he have come back to the house after she had left for college? She thought again of the rearranged cupboard, the open drawer and the muddy footprints, and tried to push aside the thought of an intruder. As the full force of her suspicion hit her, she realised that she would have to look in all the other rooms to dispel it.

3 She could feel her heart pounding against her ribs as she opened the kitchen door and ventured into the hallway. The living room bore the signs of family life, and it was completely unremarkable – just the sagging sofa, a slightly dusty table and chairs, bookshelves, the television, some newspapers and magazines. Upstairs, she stopped briefly to peek into the bathroom. The closed door of her parents' bedroom creaked open ominously, but revealed the room to be as tidy as it always was, except for three pairs of her mother's shoes lying on the floor, no doubt considered ultimately to have been too much for her already bulging suitcase. She arrived at her own bedroom door, inundated with fear, but managing to ignore the fact that she was sweating. There was nothing odd there, and James's room was, presumably, as he had left it. Emma looked at its dismally familiar features – books strewn across the desk, the occasional sock languishing on the floor and a rugby ball sitting on, of all places, James's pillow. Relief flooded over her as she was now convinced that, apart from herself, the house was empty.

4 Soon the groceries had been put away, the kitchen floor was washed, and the evening meal was on the table. When Emma opened the door to her brother, he slung his school blazer on the hall dresser, caught the significance of his sister's scowl, and went upstairs with it. Surreptitiously, Emma glanced at his shoes to check for mud, hoping for further ammunition for the impending battle. The cleanliness of his shoes, however, jangled a little bell in her head as they sat down to eat. Oblivious to his sister's mood, James rattled on to her about the runs he had scored in the cricket match at school. 'James,' Emma interjected, 'why did you come home from school today, when you know Mum and Dad wouldn't have liked it? I understand that coping with some classes might not be easy, but all of us have to face up to our responsibilities. In any case, you should have known you'd be found out.'

5 James stared at his sister with a look of undisguised puzzlement, which made her realise that what he was about to say was true. 'But I didn't come home,' he protested. 'Why on earth would I want to do that?' Emma blurted out her story: the kitchen cupboard, the open drawer, the muddy footprints. James responded with derision. 'Why would anyone want to steal teabags and spoons?' he laughed, before realising that an intruder might want to look around for valuables in cupboards and drawers. Hadn't he heard of people keeping money and jewellery in the strangest of places? At that point a loud insistent knocking came from inside the cupboard in the hall, the one which could be opened only from the outside.

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